

## FASHION ICON

## HENRIETTA MARIA



## △ TREND FOR PEARLS

Henrietta introduced fresh new styles into the English court, among them a renewed love of pearls. She proudly wore these symbols of wealth in her hair, around her neck, and as double drop earrings.

## SHIMMERING SATIN ▷

Henrietta's high-waisted gown has tabbed skirts and open three-quarter sleeves over full chemise sleeves. Her wide collar is made of lace and pearls, and she wears a ribbon sash.

The daughter of Henry IV of France and Marie de' Medici, Henrietta Maria (1609–69) married Charles I of England in 1625. She had grown up in the French court and imported grace, style, and imperial grandeur, along with a vast trousseau of clothes and jewellery. Immediately, her youth, French background, and vivacious personality introduced a new sophistication to court culture, as well as the shock of the new.

## Freer fashions

The queen made her mark through her dress sense, which was greatly admired and copied throughout Europe. Severe styles went out. Stiff brocades gave way to shiny, smooth silks, and strong, heavy colours softened. Courtiers often wore the queen's favourite colours, which were orange, blue, grey, peach, yellow, and olive-green. Henrietta abandoned the farthingale, even for formal occasions, and also the fashion for long stomachers that had pressed the farthingale flat in front to fan out behind. Full skirts were instead supported by ornamental petticoats that were visible, as the fashion was to hold up the long overskirts when walking.

Styles were relaxing. Henrietta influenced the move away from the rigid style, ruffles, and flounces of the Elizabethan era. Even ruffs were discarded in favour of wide, low collars, which gradually lowered to reveal a square-cut décolletage. Shoulders grew soft and rounded as the waistline rose, sitting just beneath breast level in the 1630s. Henrietta adopted the *Virago* sleeve, a puffed sleeve that was drawn into the arm creating puffs. She replaced stiff hairstyles with a softer coiffure, wearing her hair flat on top but curled in soft ringlets at the side.

Henrietta's fame as a leader of fashion was mainly due to Sir Anthony van Dyck (1599–1641), a Flemish Baroque artist who became the leading court painter in England. Despite flattering his subject, van Dyck captured her regal character, whatever costume she chose to wear. The queen's niece, who knew her aunt only from van Dyck's portraits, was astonished to discover that Henrietta Maria was a very small woman, with crooked shoulders, long, skinny arms, and protruding teeth.

The Queen's passion for dancing, music, and theatre heavily influenced her style. Elaborate masques staged by Inigo Jones and Ben Jonson dramatized the ideals of the Stuart monarchy. Sumptuous costumes combined dazzling colours and languid elegance. Her attire when performing on stage outraged Puritans, who considered her choice of clothing to be extremely provocative. One famous outfit had such a low décolletage that her nipples were barely hidden.

## Toning down

Henrietta took less interest in fashion as her children and the political situation occupied more of her time and thoughts. The civil war in England in the 1640s brought women's fashion to a grinding halt and womenswear became more subdued in both England and France. High waists were lowered almost to natural level.

Supporters of the monarchy (Royalists) wore detailed and lavish fashions in rich resplendent satins, but the shock of the new was over. Henrietta's husband struggled – and failed – to hang on to the throne. He was beheaded in 1649. Henrietta was a fierce campaigner, raising funds and marshalling royal support, diverting her sartorial brilliance into political and intellectual channels.

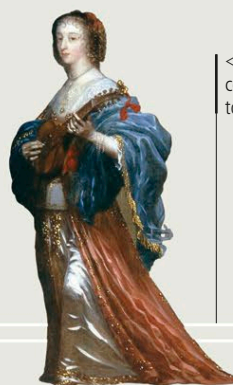


1609 Born in Paris, France

1625 The chic young Catholic bride arrives in England. In her first year of married life she wears flounced farthingale skirts and stiff upright collars, before ditching both



◁ Mid-1630s Stiff fabrics give way to lighter silks. Colours brighten with oranges and olive-greens. The *Virago* sleeve, gathered in with a ribbon or fabric to create two large puffs, becomes all the rage



◁ Late 1630s High collars and ruffs give way to lower necklines

Early 1640s As civil war approaches, fashions get simpler with natural waistlines

1669 Dies near Paris at the age of 60

○ 1610

○ 1620

○ 1630

○ 1640

○ 1650

○ 1670